

Week 1: Early Jazz

Quiz Study Guide

MUS/AAS 262 — Jazz History: Many Sounds, Many Voices
New Orleans Jazz (1900–1928)

Contents

1	Knowledge Tracker	2
2	The Era: Early Jazz / New Orleans Jazz (1900–1928)	4
2.1	What This Movement Contributes	4
2.2	Era Characteristics	4
2.3	Key Concepts	4
3	Artists and Songs	5
3.1	Scott Joplin — “Maple Leaf Rag” (1916, Piano Roll)	5
3.2	W.C. Handy — “St. Louis Blues” (1922)	5
3.3	Original Dixieland Jazz Band — “Dixie Jass Band One-Step” (1917)	5
3.4	Bessie Smith — “Backwater Blues” (1927)	6
3.5	Jelly Roll Morton — “Dead Man Blues” (1926)	6
3.6	Louis Armstrong — “West End Blues” (1928)	7
4	Listening Response Template	8
5	General Understanding	8
5.1	Movement’s Place in History	8
5.2	Cultural Context	8
5.3	Musical Revolution	8
5.4	Key Tensions	9

1 Knowledge Tracker

Move items between sections as you study. The goal is to get everything into Green.

Green — Know From Memory

- ☐ Louis Armstrong = “First Great Soloist” (Schuller)
- ☐ Jazz emphasizes beats 2 and 4 (classical = 1 and 3)

Yellow — Partial / Need Notes

- ☐ Freddie Keppard refused first recording offer (didn’t want people to copy him)
- ☐ Blues scale = pentatonic + tritone; blue notes = flat 3, flat 5, flat 7
- ☐ Heterophony = no one plays the same melodic line at the same time
- ☐ ODJB = Original Dixieland Jazz Band, first jazz recording, 1917, all-white

Red — Didn’t Know / Got Wrong

- ☐ Congo Square = where *enslaved people* in 19th-century New Orleans congregated to make music (preserved African traditions, predates jazz)
- ☐ Bessie Smith = “Empress of the Blues”; bending and sliding into notes influenced instrumentalists
- ☐ Jelly Roll Morton = Creole (mixed Black + European); claimed to have invented jazz; Red Hot Peppers
- ☐ 12-bar blues = A, A, B (4+4+4 bars) — NOT AABA (that is 32-bar form, different thing)
- ☐ Creole = mixed-race (Black + European), classically trained, barred from white orchestras

Not Yet Tested

- ☐ Scott Joplin = “King of Ragtime”; Maple Leaf Rag (1899 sheet music, 1916 piano roll)
- ☐ W.C. Handy = “Father of the Blues”; St. Louis Blues has habanera/tango rhythm (Spanish tinge)
- ☐ Armstrong invented scat singing (1926, “Heebie Jeebies”)
- ☐ Armstrong: vibrato only at END of notes (revolutionary technique)
- ☐ “West End Blues” (1928) = unaccompanied trumpet cadenza opening; written by King Oliver
- ☐ Hot Five / Hot Seven = Armstrong’s landmark recording groups (1925–1928)
- ☐ Morton’s “Dead Man Blues” (1926) = spoken dialogue intro, funeral march, Red Hot Peppers
- ☐ Bessie Smith “Backwater Blues” (1927) = dual call-and-response, James P. Johnson on piano
- ☐ ODJB “Dixie Jass Band One-Step” = marching band influence, rehearsed, minimal improv
- ☐ Handy = formally trained, first to transcribe blues into written notation
- ☐ Call and response = fundamental jazz element; “trading eights” in instrumental jazz
- ☐ Swing rhythm = dotted eighth + sixteenth, or triplet with tie on first two notes
- ☐ Baraka quote: “Blues could not exist if the African captives had not become American captives”
- ☐ New Orleans instrumentation = trumpet/cornet, clarinet, trombone (reduction of marching band)

- ☐ Ragtime = syncopated melodies, steady bass, NO improvisation, precursor to jazz
- ☐ 32-bar AABA form = popular song form (B section = bridge) — different from 12-bar blues

2 The Era: Early Jazz / New Orleans Jazz (1900–1928)

2.1 What This Movement Contributes

1. **Birth of Jazz as a Genre** — emerged in New Orleans around 1900 as fusion of African rhythms, blues, ragtime, work songs, European harmony
2. **Collective Improvisation** — multiple instruments improvising simultaneously (heterophony)
3. **Louis Armstrong's Revolution** — transformed jazz from ensemble music to soloist's art form; invented scat singing
4. **Blues Form Codification** — 12-bar blues structure (A, A, B) became foundational
5. **Commercial Viability** — first jazz recordings spread the music beyond New Orleans

2.2 Era Characteristics

- **Rhythmic Feel:** Swing rhythm (dotted eighth + sixteenth, or triplet with tie); beats 2 and 4
- **Ensemble Style:** Small groups; trumpet/cornet, clarinet, trombone as core (reduction of marching band)
- **Improvisation:** Collective improvisation; heterophony
- **Blues Influence:** Blues scale (pentatonic + tritone), blue notes (flat 3, flat 5, flat 7), call and response
- **Recording Tech:** Limited to ~3 minutes per disc side
- **Sound:** Instrumental playing mimics vocal techniques (bends, moans, vibrato)

2.3 Key Concepts

- **Congo Square:** Where enslaved people in 19th-century New Orleans congregated to make music
- **Heterophony:** No one plays the same melodic line at the same time
- **Blues Structure:** A, A, B form; each section = 4 bars (12 bars total)
- **Blues Scale:** Pentatonic scale + tritone (the “Devil’s Interval”)
- **Call and Response:** Biggest element of jazz; became “trading eights” in instrumental jazz
- **Swing Rhythm:** Dotted eighth + sixteenth, or triplet with tie on first two notes
- **Creole:** Mixed-race (Black + European), classically trained, barred from white orchestras
- **Baraka quote:** “Blues could not exist if the African captives had not become American captives”

3 Artists and Songs

3.1 Scott Joplin — “Maple Leaf Rag” (1916, Piano Roll)

Era: Ragtime (precursor to jazz), late 1890s–1910s

Key Facts

1. “King of Ragtime”
2. Published as sheet music in 1899 — one of first to sell over 1 million copies
3. 1916 recording is a piano roll, not live — played back mechanically
4. Ragtime = syncopated melodies against steady bass; direct precursor to jazz
5. NO improvisation — fully composed and notated
6. Born 1868 (right after Emancipation), died 1917

Instrumentation: Solo piano (mechanical piano roll)

Song Form: Multi-strain (AABBACCDD); NOT 12-bar blues or 32-bar AABA

Listen For: Syncopated melody over steady “oom-pah” bass, stiff/mechanical rhythm, no swing feel, bright/playful, clear repeated sections, no improvisation

3.2 W.C. Handy — “St. Louis Blues” (1922)

Era: Early Jazz / Blues (1910s–1920s)

Key Facts

1. “Father of the Blues”
2. Composed 1914, this recording 1922
3. Formally trained; first to transcribe and publish blues in written notation
4. Habanera (tango) rhythm in middle section — Cuban influence (“Spanish tinge”)
5. Bandleader, not rural folk musician — professional, literate Black musician class
6. Pianist and trumpet player

Instrumentation: Small ensemble — trumpet (muted and open), clarinet, piano, bass, drums

Song Form: Blues-based but complex; sections switch between swung/straight, minor/major; tango section in middle

Listen For: Highly composed, very little improvisation, polyphony to monophony, swung vs. straight switches, minor/major shifts, muted trumpet timbre, tango rhythm

3.3 Original Dixieland Jazz Band — “Dixie Jass Band One-Step” (1917)

Era: Early Jazz / New Orleans Jazz (1917)

Key Facts

1. First commercially released jazz recording (1917, Victor Records)
2. All-white band — brought jazz to mainstream white audiences
3. Freddie Keppard (Black cornet player) refused first chance to record — feared copying
4. Clearly rehearsed with minimal improvisation — strong marching band influence
5. From New Orleans, breakthrough in Chicago and New York
6. Originally spelled “J-A-S-S” (later “J-A-Z-Z”)

Instrumentation: Trumpet/cornet, clarinet, trombone, piano, drums (marching band tradition)

Song Form: Multi-strain ragtime-influenced; highly rehearsed

Listen For: Marching band feel, stiff/military, clearly rehearsed, minimal improv, trumpet/clarinet/trombone lines, sounds like ragtime, no real soloists

3.4 Bessie Smith — “Backwater Blues” (1927)

Era: Classic Blues / Early Jazz (1920s)

Key Facts

1. “Empress of the Blues” (1894–1937) — most commercially successful blues artist of 1920s
2. Inspired by Great Mississippi Flood of 1927
3. Two simultaneous call-and-responses — vocal/piano AND within vocal phrasing
4. Bending and sliding into notes — pattern instrumentalists later imitated
5. Columbia Records; James P. Johnson on piano
6. Darker timbre, extensive vibrato

Instrumentation: Voice (lead) + Piano (James P. Johnson)

Song Form: 12-bar blues (A, A, B); each section = 4 bars

Listen For: Dual call-and-response, vocal bending/sliding (blue notes), dark timbre, heavy vibrato, piano fills between vocal phrases, emotional storytelling

3.5 Jelly Roll Morton — “Dead Man Blues” (1926)

Era: Early Jazz / New Orleans Jazz (1920s)

Key Facts

1. Born Ferdinand Joseph LaMothe (1890–1941); Creole — mixed-race, classically trained, barred from white orchestras
2. Claimed to have invented jazz

3. Opens with spoken dialogue mimicking African American speech
4. Recorded with Red Hot Peppers for Victor Records
5. Highly arranged yet swinging
6. Nickname from playing piano at houses of prostitution
7. Pioneering jazz composer/arranger

Instrumentation: New Orleans ensemble — trumpet, clarinet, trombone, piano, banjo/guitar, drums, tuba/bass

Song Form: New Orleans funeral march; arranged sections with space for improvisation

Listen For: Spoken intro dialogue, funeral march / second line rhythm, collective improvisation, ragtime influence / stiff rhythm, clarinet and trumpet solos, more composed than improvised

3.6 Louis Armstrong — “West End Blues” (1928)

Era: Early Jazz / New Orleans Jazz (late 1920s)

Key Facts

1. Opens with unaccompanied trumpet cadenza — landmark in jazz history
2. “First Great Soloist” (Schuller Ch. 3) — transformed jazz from ensemble to soloist’s art
3. First to play vibrato only at END of note — influenced every instrument since
4. Hot Five and Hot Seven recordings (1925–1928) = most important in jazz history
5. Written by King Oliver, Armstrong’s mentor who brought him to Chicago
6. Born 1901 New Orleans, died 1971; self-taught orphan
7. Invented scat singing in 1926 with “Heebie Jeebies”

Instrumentation: Trumpet (Armstrong), clarinet, trombone, piano, banjo, drums (Hot Five combo)

Song Form: 12-bar blues; opens with unaccompanied trumpet cadenza

Listen For: Iconic trumpet cadenza opening, strident/bright trumpet sound, vibrato at END of notes, improvised solo, trumpet mirrors vocal phrasing, blues structure

4 Listening Response Template

Name, composer, and year are PROVIDED on the quiz. Focus on what you HEAR. Aim for 5 observations:

1. **Instrumentation/Ensemble** — What instruments? Solo, combo, or large group? Who is soloist?
2. **Era/Style** — Ragtime, early blues, New Orleans jazz? What clues? (collective improv = early; virtuoso solo = Armstrong; stiff rhythm = ragtime)
3. **Rhythm/Feel** — Swinging or straight? Fast/slow? Beats 2 and 4? Syncopated? Second line?
4. **Melody/Improvisation** — Melody stated or improvised? Collective or solo improv? Bending, sliding, vibrato?
5. **Texture/Form/Special** — Dense or sparse? 12-bar blues, AABA, ragtime strains? Call and response? Special features (spoken intro, cadenza, muted trumpet, scat)?
6. **Emotion/Context** — What feeling? How does it connect to readings?

Template: “This piece features [instruments], with [soloist] as the primary voice. The style is [era/style] based on [clues]. The form is [form], evidenced by [what you hear]. A notable feature is [detail], which connects to [course concept].”

5 General Understanding

5.1 Movement’s Place in History

- New Orleans birthplace: unique confluence of African, European, Caribbean, Creole cultures
- Congo Square: preserved African musical traditions that fed into jazz
- Ragtime (composed, syncopated) + Blues (vocal, 12-bar) = Early Jazz (improvised, ensemble)
- Jazz spread from New Orleans to Chicago and New York during Great Migration
- First recordings (1917): white musicians profited from Black innovation

5.2 Cultural Context

- Minstrelsy: Armstrong criticized as “old Negro” for entertaining persona
- Creole class: classically trained but barred from white orchestras
- Harlem Renaissance: “New Negro” movement for Black artistic legitimacy
- Colorism: paper bag test at Cotton Club

5.3 Musical Revolution

- African (polyrhythm, syncopation, call-response) + European (harmony, notation, phrase structure)
- Collective improvisation (heterophony) was precursor to solo improvisation
- Armstrong shifted jazz from ensemble to soloist’s art
- Instrumental jazz mimicked vocal techniques from blues singers like Bessie Smith

5.4 Key Tensions

- **Composed vs. Improvised:** ragtime composed; Armstrong introduced spontaneous improvisation
- **Entertainment vs. Art:** early jazz was dance music; tension with artistic legitimacy
- **Black Innovation, White Profit:** ODJB recorded first after Keppard refused
- **Preservation vs. Evolution:** Morton stayed 1920s style; Armstrong pushed forward